

Introduction

One of the biggest challenges for community rehabilitation providers (CRPs) has been finding and retaining direct support professional (DSP) staff to provide high-quality employment and community services for individuals with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD). A recent survey of more than 500 service providers across 45 states and Washington, DC revealed that 95% of providers reported facing moderate or severe staffing shortages over the past year (ANCOR, 2023). Furthermore, 77% of the providers reported turning away new referrals due to the shortages.

In the 2023 State of the Workforce survey, of over 3,900 provider agencies representing 26 states and Washington, DC, there was an average reported turnover ratio of 40% (NCI IDD, 2024). The survey also found that 66% of DSPs at participating agencies were employed for less than one year, demonstrating that most DSPs leave their positions in their first year. Provider staff turnover has been a longstanding issue across the US. States' Medicaid reimbursement rates, which serve as the primary funding source for many CRPs, have created fiscal barriers in hiring and retaining staff. With a median hourly wage of \$14.50, providers struggle to compete financially with industries like retail and fast food (ANCOR, 2023).

While state and federal policies have begun to prioritize integrated employment and community engagement, there are challenges within CRPs that impact capacity and service provision. Service providers' capacity is challenged by funding constraints, the need to offer both work and non-work supports, and the lack of professional development opportunities that could increase efficiency of service provision (Winsor et al., 2022). These organizational challenges were exacerbated by the COVID-19 Public Health Emergency (PHE), which required providers to reconsider where and how to deliver services. Some organizations transitioned all their work out of CRP-owned buildings and into communities and began delivering services remotely in an effort to serve individuals effectively and efficiently. As providers consider the impact of changing federal and state policies in conjunction with the real effects of the recent PHE, the question of how to increase capacity by finding and retaining staff remains.

This brief highlights promising practices identified across five CRPs in Washington, Minnesota, and Wisconsin. The CRPs included:

1. Advance Opportunities (MN)
2. Training Support Employment, Inc (TSE, MN)
3. Udac (MN)
4. Rise (MN/WI)
5. Trillium (WA)



In the past four years, these agencies have implemented new and creative strategies to overcome staffing shortages. The brief draws findings from in-depth, semi-structured interviews with leaders and staff of the agencies. We present the promising practices these CRPs used as well as suggestions for other service CRPs to replicate these strategies.

Promising Practices

We identified three key areas of practice across the CRPs. These strategies fell into three main themes:

1. **Aligning recruitment with organizational mission**
2. **Focusing on job training and skill development**
3. **Creating a culture that values employees**

Aligning Recruitment with Organizational Mission

Each CRP shared that they made changes to their hiring processes to enhance recruitment. Rise intentionally changed their job postings, information on their website, and modes of communication to reach more potential applicants. They also began using software to send texts to job applicants versus emails to communicate in a format that is better aligned with the applicants' preferences. The human resources staff at Rise focused on revising language in job postings to concretely describe the job responsibilities in a way that emphasized the day-to-day activities, positive impact of the work, and the opportunities the job presents to applicants.

TSE similarly shifted job postings to emphasize quality of life and passion for working with individuals with IDD. An administrator at TSE shared that the organization “aims to hire high-talent staff who are invested in the mission.” This was a practice we found at other providers. Similarly, both Udac and Advance Opportunities placed increased value on recruiting staff who were passionate about supporting people with IDD, while Trillium partnered with community-based organizations to recruit from a wider pool of individuals than they could reach through traditional search engines. The Udac Executive Director stated: “We recognize that we cannot have a quality program without talented, quality employees who really understand how to help people with IDD become part of their community... [we] set out to deliberately look for talent and retain that talent.”

Shifting recruitment and hiring strategies requires time and resources. One provider, Advance Opportunities, designated specific staff for human resources activities to accommodate the changes to their recruitment practices. Advance Opportunities merged with another provider, which extended the opportunity to create staff with full-time human resources responsibilities. Previously, the Chief Operating Officer and office managers had shared responsibility for recruitment and hiring practices.

Focusing on Job Training and Skill Development

Shifting recruitment processes to focus on bringing in dedicated individuals also meant a shift toward a strengths-focused approach to onboarding and developing staff. Simple strategies, like requesting feedback from existing staff on established onboarding processes, led to important shifts in each organization that improved staff retention.

At Rise, feedback from staff highlighted the dislike for the remote onboarding process that had been established during the PHE, which led to the transition to in-person onboarding for all new staff. Advance Opportunities identified that their short-term onboarding

processes led to gaps in employee knowledge and skills. As a result, they developed a formal mentorship program for new staff to have ongoing support as they oriented themselves to their role. Trillium similarly uses a 6-month mentorship program and collects feedback from staff at the end of the onboarding period, which has led staff to feel increased confidence and express appreciation for the longer-term support.

Several of the agencies also placed new emphasis on professional development. This included creating clear roles, responsibilities, and pathways for growth within the agency, and providing opportunities for such growth. Udac, Rise, and Trillium all focused on providing different types of training for different staff, taking a person-centered approach to increase employees' skills and confidence, ultimately leading to potential internal promotions.

Creating a Culture that Values Employees

A major theme among the CRPs' strategies was the creation of a workplace culture that prioritizes positive working relationships and celebrates staff. Creating a friendly workplace where staff feel comfortable asking for help and learning new skills has led to increased staff retention. The Advance Opportunities CEO spoke to this, saying "we're focusing on creating an atmosphere where everybody has someone they look forward to seeing at work."

One approach Advance used to create a sense of community was through opportunities like having the office manager bring lunch for new employees' first day of orientation and having a few staff members join them to engage the new employee with colleagues. TSE uses a weekly newsletter to highlight staff achievements and dedicates surplus funds each year to monetarily reward excellent work. Similarly, Rise developed a recognition committee to honor staff achievements during Direct Support Professionals' appreciation week.

Investing in staff through offering competitive wages, sign-on bonuses, and stay-on bonuses is another strategy that has resulted in staff feeling valued. Advance Opportunities offered sign-on and referral bonuses for a limited time, which led to five new hires. Trillium reviewed its hiring data and found that most employees came to the organization through referrals. As a result, they implemented referral and sign-on bonuses to boost their hiring and recognize the value of referrals from any staff members, regardless of tenure. TSE demonstrated a culture of value for employees by using cash reserves and federal funding opportunities to offer \$5 per hour raises to its staff during the COVID-19 PHE. TSE also implemented stay-on bonuses for new employees who reached 1-month, 6-month, and 12-month milestones with the organization. These cash incentives create a more competitive employment opportunity for CRPs and establish a work culture that values its employees' efforts and dedication.

Strategies for Employment Providers to Consider

- » **Be creative with your recruitment.** Focus on shifting recruitment in ways that can increase your reach by building community relationships to reach a wider audience. When recruiting and advertising, highlight the importance of the work versus the experience required. Remember to communicate in ways that are accessible and clear to reach all potential applicants.
- » **Invest in your employees.** Allocate resources to benefit employees. Focusing resources on internal growth opportunities—individualized mentorship, professional development, and skills-based training—will promote staff retention. In addition, sign-

on, stay-on, and referral bonuses can quickly increase your hiring pool and show that employees are valued members of the team.

- » **Build a culture of respect.** Create an environment where employees feel their individual skills are valued, where they are safe to ask questions, and where their feedback is clearly considered. Promote open communication and a sense of respect through opportunities for staff to connect formally and informally with colleagues and supervisors. Creating a more positive workplace culture can also be as simple as weekly newsletters to highlight individual staff achievements.

Conclusion

Policy shifts from facility-based toward community-based services and the impact of the COVID-19 PHE have compelled CRPs to find innovative ways to recruit and maintain staff. This study's findings highlighted that hiring and retaining quality staff is possible if CRPs are willing to invest in their employees, be creative in their hiring approaches, and accentuate respect and appreciation for their dedicated, hardworking team. A common theme across the agencies was recognizing the value of recruiting and retaining employees who express an interest in career growth and a clear understanding of the impact of their job on people with IDD. Agencies saw positive outcomes when focusing on creating an environment that valued individual employee strengths, supported employee development, and promoted transparency around roles and opportunities. These promising practices can guide CRPs to build hiring and retention strategies that ensure they have staff to support individuals with IDD toward reaching employment goals.

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